DAILY READING • 样张

# The Paper Crown

2026-11-06 · 当天 50 词全部覆盖 · 全文 639 词 · 5 段

短文

The village hall smelled of floor wax and wet stone when Eli carried the first chairs inside. He spotted the bend in the steel rod before he set the chairs down. The marquee frame sagged like a tired sail, and the banner could not hang until it was straight. The nylon strap holding two frame sections together was frayed, so he wound tape around it. Aunt Rosa governed the kitchen like a dictator, and she had already banned him from the door. The keeper's residence behind the stage had been turned into a store room for crockery. He crawled under a trestle table to reach the box of screws pushed against the wall. He tightened three loose bolts with a borrowed wrench and stepped back to study the frame.

The seating plan required an accord between two families who had not spoken since March. Eli spread the chart out and rearranged the rows accordingly, moving the loud cousins to the back. His grandmother treated that chart like a religion, since the order of names decided the mood. The notion that every guest must face the band was hers, and nobody had questioned it. Each individual place card had to be written by hand, which took him most of the afternoon. He worried about the welfare of the children near the open door, where the draught was cold. The most influential woman in the room claimed the seat beside the marquee pole. Every time he puzzled over a name, she leaned across and moved it herself.

At four the power failed for ninety minutes, and the kitchen fridge went warm in the dark. By the time the lights returned, a tray of chicken had sat out long enough for bacteria to double. His concentration broke when the smell reached him across the corridor, and he knew what it meant. A concerning sweetness hung over the counter, and the meat had turned a colour he disliked. The caterer's plates were of an inferior grade, thin enough to bend in the hand. The florist had gone bankrupt in September, so the tables would carry artificial roses. The bride's boss, a regional executive, was coming, and her promotion depended on the room. A destructive rumour had already started among the aunts, and he needed absolute quiet.

The revelation came at six, when the band's driver called to say the van had broken down. Eli began an investigation of his own, which meant three calls and a walk to the pub. He chased the landlord down the lane and asked whether the folk trio still played on Fridays. An accidental meeting at the bar became a booking, and the trio arrived within the hour. Their style had evolved from a tradition different in origin from the songs the bride loved. The evening had to undergo one more change before it could settle into a shape. The most noticeable characteristic of the new band was its age, and the grandmother approved. He wrote the specific times on a card and taped it to the kitchen door.

By midnight the hall stood ready, and Eli polished the last wine glasses with a soft cloth. The work relieved him more than sleep would have, because it left nothing for tomorrow. He reckoned the floor would survive the heels, though the varnish was already marked. A colony of wasps had built under the eaves, and he decided to leave them alone. The lamps cast a warm band across the tables and the paper crown for the flower girl. At the far end of the lawn the flag pole stood black against a gorgeous sky. His first impression of the hall had been of a cold room, and the original plan was gone. He walked the length of the marquee once more to inspect the ropes and the stakes.

解析 · 行间留白，可直接手写

The village hall smelled of **floor wax** and wet stone when Eli carried the first chairs inside. He spotted the bend in the steel rod before he set the chairs down. The marquee frame sagged like a tired sail, and the banner could not hang until it was straight. The nylon strap holding two frame sections together was frayed, so he wound tape around it. Aunt Rosa governed the kitchen like a dictator, and she had already **banned him from** the door. The keeper's residence behind the stage had been turned into a store room for crockery. He crawled under a trestle table to reach the box of screws pushed against the wall. He **tightened three loose bolts** with a borrowed wrench and stepped back to study the frame.

> **floor wax** 地板蜡 wax 作物质名词不可数，不说 a floor wax；动词搭配是 wax the floor（给地板打蜡）
> **banned him from** 禁止他进入（某处） ban sb from sth / from doing sth，from 后接地点或动名词；名词形式是 a ban on sth
> **tightened three loose bolts** 把三颗松动的螺栓拧紧 tighten 直接接被拧紧的物件，也可说 tighten a screw / nut；反义是 loosen，名词是 torque（扭矩）

The seating plan required **an accord between** two families who had not spoken since March. Eli spread the chart out and rearranged the rows accordingly, moving the loud cousins to the back. His grandmother treated that chart **like a religion**, since the order of names decided the mood. The notion that every guest must face the band was hers, and nobody had questioned it. Each individual place card had to be written by hand, which took him most of the afternoon. He worried about **the welfare of** the children near the open door, where the draught was cold. The most influential woman in the room claimed the seat beside the marquee pole. Every time he puzzled over a name, she leaned across and moved it herself.

> **an accord between** （两方之间的）协议 accord 作名词偏正式，多用于外交与劳资语境；between 后接双方，动词搭配是 reach / sign an accord
>
> **like a religion** 像信教一样（不容置疑地）对待 treat sth like a religion 是夸张说法，指把某事当成不可违背的信条；religion 泛指宗教时可数，指信仰体系时常不可数
>
> **the welfare of** ……的安康、福祉 welfare 不可数，后接 of 指明对象；指人的安危用 the welfare of sb，指社会保障制度时单独用 welfare

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> **sat out** （食物）摆在外面没冷藏 此处 sit out 指被搁置在外；另有 sit out a dance / a game，指坐在一旁不参加，两个义项靠宾语区分
> **of an inferior grade** 次一等的（货色） grade 表等级，of … grade 作后置定语；比较两物优劣用 inferior to，不用 inferior than
> **gone bankrupt** 破产 go 后接形容词表状态转变，不加冠词；及物说法是 bankrupt a company，名词是 bankruptcy

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> **an investigation of his own** 他自己的一番调查 惯用 conduct / launch an investigation into sth；of his own 表“属于他自己的”，与 into 引出的调查对象不冲突
> **different in origin from** 来源上与……不同 in origin 作状语，表“在来源上”；origin 与 of 搭配指来源，复数 origins 则指出身背景
> **had to undergo** 不得不经历 undergo 后接名词，如 change / training / tests，不用进行时；过去分词是 undergone，不是 undergoed

By midnight the hall stood ready, and Eli polished the last wine glasses with a soft cloth. The work relieved him more than sleep would have, because it left nothing for tomorrow. He reckoned the floor would survive the heels, though the varnish was already marked. **A colony of wasps** had built under the eaves, and he decided to leave them alone. The lamps **cast a warm band** across the tables and the paper crown for the flower girl. At the far end of the lawn the flag pole stood black against a gorgeous sky. His **first impression of** the hall had been of a cold room, and the original plan was gone. He walked the length of the marquee once more to inspect the ropes and the stakes.

> **A colony of wasps** 一窝黄蜂 colony 指群居动物的群体，a colony of ants / bees / wasps；指殖民地时是另一个政治义项
> **cast a warm band** 投下一道暖光 cast 后接光、影、目光：cast light on、cast a shadow；cast 的过去式与过去分词同形，不加 -ed
> **first impression of** 对……的第一印象 impression 与 of 搭配指印象的对象，与 on 搭配指给某人留下的印象，如 make an impression on sb

## 译文

埃利把第一批椅子搬进去时，村礼堂里是地板蜡和湿石头的气味。椅子还没放下，他就看见了那根钢杆上的弯。头顶的帐篷框像一张累了的帆那样塌着，横幅得等它扶正才能挂。把两截框架系在一起的尼龙带有一头磨散了，他用胶带缠了几圈。罗莎姨把厨房管得像个独裁者，早就禁止他进门。舞台后面看管人的住宅已经改成了放碗碟的储藏室。他爬到一张搁板桌底下，去够被人推到墙边的螺丝盒。他用借来的扳手把三颗松动的螺栓拧紧，退后一步打量整副框架。

座位图需要两个从三月起就没说过话的家庭达成一份协议。埃利把图摊开，相应地重排各排，把爱吵的那几个表亲挪到后面。他祖母把这张图当成宗教一样信奉，因为在她看来，名字的顺序决定婚礼的气场。每位客人都必须正对乐队这个观念是她提出来的，没人敢质疑。每一张个人名牌都得手写，这花了他大半个下午。他还担心靠敞开门那几个孩子的安危，那里穿堂风很冷。屋里最有影响力的女人占了帐篷立柱边的座位。每次他对着一个名字犯难，她就探过身来自己动手挪。

四点钟停电停了九十分钟，厨房的冰箱在黑暗里变温了。等灯回来时，一盘鸡肉在外面摆得太久，细菌足够翻上两番。那股气味从走廊那头飘过来时，他的专注一下子断了，他知道那意味着什么。柜台上浮着一层令人担心的甜味，肉的颜色也变成了他不喜欢的样子。承办商的盘子本来就是次一等的货色，薄得能在手里弯。花店九月就破产了，所以桌上摆的会是人造玫瑰。新娘的老板是位区域主管，也要来，而她的晋升取决于这个厅的样子。一个破坏性的传言已经在姑婶们中间传开，他需要绝对的安静。

六点钟来了一桩内情：乐队的司机打电话说车坏在路上了。埃利开始了一场自己的调查，也就是三个电话加一趟去酒馆的路。他沿小路追上房东，问那支民谣三重奏周五是否还演出。在吧台的一次偶遇变成了一桩预订，三重奏一小时内就到了。他们的风格是从一个来源不同于新娘所爱歌曲的传统里演变出来的。这个晚上还得再经历一次变动，才能定下形状。新乐队最显而易见的特征是年纪，祖母立刻点了头。他把明确的时刻写在卡片上，贴到厨房门上。

到午夜，礼堂已经就绪，埃利用一块软布擦亮了最后几只酒杯。这活儿给他的宽慰超过睡觉，因为它没给明天留下任何事。他估计地板扛得住高跟鞋，尽管漆面已经被划了。屋檐下结了一窝黄蜂，他决定不去动它们。灯光在桌面上投下一道暖光，也照在给花童的那顶纸王冠上。草坪尽头，旗杆在黑里立着，背后是一片极漂亮的天空。他对这个厅的第一印象是间冷屋子，而原先的计划已经不在了。他又沿着帐篷走了一遍，检查绳子和地钉。